

SPELT

The great leap forward for wheats came when emmer crossed, or hybridized, with wild goat grass that was growing as a weed in wheat fields. The result was spelt wheat, which is still cultivated in parts of northwest Europe.

WHEATFIELD PRAIRIE

Today's wheat is much shorter than that of a century ago. Breeders have reduced the amount of stalk, so that the plant does not bend over, making it difficult to harvest the grain. This is an important step forward for the major grain-producing countries of the world, where vast areas of wheat are grown.



Spelt grains

The long, spiked bristles attached to scales around each grain are called awns

Durum wheat

Pasta shells

DURUM WHEAT

Another large-grain wheat closely related to emmer is durum, or macaroni, wheat. It is grown widely today to provide the flour for pasta and cookies. Because its gluten content is low, it does not make good bread. Modern durum wheat has bigger grains as a result of intensive breeding.

Bread wheat

Grains of bread wheat

Uncooked wholewheat flour

BREAD WHEAT

Bread wheat is also a hybrid of emmer and wild goat grass, and it is the most widely grown modern wheat. Its large grains have a high gluten content, which makes bread dough elastic and enables light, airy bread to be made.

White bread, made from very finely ground flour that has been bleached

Brown bread baked with unbleached wholewheat flour